

The Michigan Christian Journal

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Dear reader,

The Michigan Christian Journal is a student-led publication at the University of Michigan that seeks to engage in intellectual debate and discussion of theological issues and contemporary Christian issues on campus and beyond. It was created with the intention of allowing Christian students on campus a place to educate, discuss, and debate issues that are important to our identity in Christ and on campus.

The journey to get to this, the first publication of the Michigan Christian Journal, has been an interesting one. The efforts and hard work of many people made what you are about to read possible. I would like to take this opportunity to thank a few of them here.

I would like to thank those who have inspired me to take this first step and create this organization. The influence of my pastors, friends, family, and other authors has shown me the need for an organization like this at the University of Michigan. Their inspiration and support have helped encourage me to pursue this goal and get to where we are today.

To the inaugural members of the Michigan Christian Journal, thanks for sticking with me. It takes a certain courage to be willing to jump aboard this frantically and chaotically organized club with such enthusiasm. Your ideas and passion for your work inspired me and make all this hard work worthwhile.

Finally, I would like to thank you, the reader, for taking the time to read this journal and to appreciate the hard work of our writing team. We hope that you can learn something new, or be inspired by our work to do good things on campus and beyond. If you would like to join us on this journey or have any questions or comments, please feel free to contact me using the information below. I look forward to hearing from you.

In Christ,

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Table of Contents

Scripture and Gospel	4
The Gospel - Eli Grewell	5
In the Potter's Hand: An Exploration of the Sovereignty of God in Ephesians 1: 3-14 - Kevin Fan	9
Life and Campus	18
Dating IRL - Esmee Kuiper and Sommer Motley	19
How Studying the Bible Enriches the Beauty of My Religion - Sommer Motley	27
Making Amends - Daniel Koning	30
Character Matters - Ethan Wilmot	33
Testimonies	36
Discernment - Ivan Kalla	37
Creative Writing	41
The One Who Sees Me - Sommer Motley	42
Healing in His Wings - Kevin Fan	45
In the Hands of My Great Savior - Kevin Fan	46
O Gracious Lord - Kevin Fan	47

Scripture and Gospel

The Gospel

By: Eli Grewell

“It’s greater than religion. It’s the power of the cross” (Ryan Stevenson’s “The Gospel”). The Cross. It’s everywhere, isn’t it? But what does it mean? Is it simply just for show? And if it is just a statement piece, what power could it possibly hold?

The Cross is representative of the most important part of the Gospel, Jesus’ death and resurrection. The Cross itself has no power; however, its symbolic nature is a unifying factor between all believers, and a reminder of why we believe. That is its true power and why it is seen all over the world. Nonetheless, there are some theological discrepancies between all the different types of Christianities and similar theological sects. Catholics have different views than Orthodox Christians who have different views from non-denominational Christians and so forth. Yet there are a few fundamental truths that remain the same. They are laid out in the Apostles’ Creed which is a collective work that describes the fundamental truths of Christianity written by church leaders around 700 AD. It says:

I believe in God the Father almighty,
Creator of heaven and earth.
And in Jesus Christ, His only Son,
our Lord, Who was conceived by the Holy Spirit,
born of the Virgin Mary,
suffered under Pontius Pilate,
was crucified, died, and was buried.
He descended into hell; the third day
He rose again from the dead;
He ascended into heaven, and sits at
the right hand of God the Father
almighty, from thence He shall come
to judge the living and the dead.
I believe in the Holy Spirit,
the holy Catholic Church,
the communion of saints,
the forgiveness of sins,
the resurrection of the body
and life everlasting.
Amen.

The Apostles’ Creed is a good starting point, but it doesn’t explain why any of the things referenced in it are important. This article will address the importance of the beliefs mentioned in

this Creed, while simultaneously outlining the Gospel. The gospels, Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John, are four books of the Bible that are entirely about Jesus' life on Earth. The Gospel is a summary of the gospels as well as some other Old Testament information that is important context for different aspects of the life of Jesus. This Gospel is the foundation of the Christian faith and therefore is very important for believers and nonbelievers alike to understand. But in order to understand the Gospel you have to start at the very beginning.

“In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth”(Genesis 1:1). A world devoid of life, formless and pointless. But good news! During a period of 6 days, the entire world was created, and it was good. On the last day, “God created mankind in his own image, in the image of God he created them; male and female he created them” (Genesis 1:27). This was very good. The best thing about this creation? Everything was perfect. God did not make a single mistake, and the Earth existed in perfect harmony, at least for a while. There was one tree at the center of the Garden of Eden that Adam and Eve, the first man and woman, were commanded not to eat from. This was the tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil. However, the devil, in the form of a serpent, tempted Eve with the desire to be equal with God, knowing both good and evil. Succumbing to the deception of the serpent, both Eve and Adam took a bite of the forbidden fruit, and sin and death entered the world. Since this moment there has been an issue with sin, and this sin is the catalyst for the good news of the Gospel.

As humans, sin is a part of our nature. Since birth, all people have sinned, in some form or another, millions upon millions of times. Sin is, simply put, disobedience to God. As Christians, we believe we are meant for a personal and close relationship with God. When we sin it acts like a wedge, driving between us and God, separating us from Him. The only way to restore this relationship is to somehow remove this sin barrier. In the Old Testament, there was a list of rules and regulations (613 laws in total) for the cleansing of sin. Whenever a sin was committed, the Israelites were expected to atone for the sin, often in the form of an animal sacrifice. This list of rules was strictly followed and enforced, but in reality it is impossible to atone for every sin. Another solution was required to truly cleanse the Israelites, and the rest of the world, from their sins. As time went on the Israelites' lives didn't get any easier. They were conquered by surrounding nations, taken captive, and their way of life was slowly getting destroyed. Around this same time, the prophets, people who deliver messages from God, started prophesying about a Messiah, someone who would be king over Israel. This Messiah would deliver the Israelites from captivity and make them a strong nation. The people expected a fiery chariot from the sky to bring down a warrior ready to smite the enemies of Israel, but that is not how this story goes.

One night a woman named Mary finds out from an angel, Gabriel, that she is pregnant. Gabriel says this,
““Do not be afraid, Mary; you have found favor with God. You will conceive and give birth to a son, and you are to call him Jesus. He will be great and will be called the Son of the Most High [this is because he was in fact God in the flesh]. The Lord God will give him the throne of his

father David, and he will reign over Jacob's descendants forever; his kingdom will never end'" (Luke 1:30-33).

However, Mary is a virgin, and also betrothed to a man named Joseph. Having a child out of wedlock while being betrothed to a man who knew the child wasn't his would make Mary a cultural pariah, and yet she rejoiced at this proclamation because she knew that God had a plan, and He chose her to be a part of it. An angel later appears to Joseph and explains that Mary is having a child and why he should remain with Mary despite not being its father. The baby Jesus was born in a manger in Bethlehem and a star lit up the sky as a beacon to signify the birth of the Messiah. Jesus grew up and led a life without sin, setting an example for believers on how to live their lives. Jesus was also a teacher, and he drew many crowds with his preaching due to the simplicity of his words and the parables he used to convey his points. Jesus became a well known figure in many communities for his signs of healing, miracles, teaching, and knowledge. This attention was not always good, and many people were waiting for evidence that he was not the Messiah, yet none came. Eventually, one of Jesus' disciples, Judas, betrayed Jesus for 30 silver coins and turned him over to the Roman authorities. During his trial, the people voted to kill Jesus by crucifixion. Jesus was beaten, whipped, jeered, spit on, and forced to wear a crown of thorns. Then he was hung up on the cross and he died. As he hung there dying, his last words were, "'It is finished'" (John 19:30).

However, even death cannot hold Jesus! Three days later he rose from the dead, conquering sin and death, just as it was prophesied in the Old Testament. The death and resurrection of Jesus are the key components of the Gospel. This goes back to the problem of sin. People are simply not able to atone for their sins by themselves. The consequence of sin is death and permanent separation from God, and all of us deserve to die for our sins. However, Jesus took on the sins of the world while he was on the cross and died for our sins. His resurrection three days later assures us of the fact that he is greater than Hell, and death cannot hold him. This is the message of the Gospel. Jesus even confirms this when he says, "It is finished" (John 19:30). This refers to the fact that he was sent to Earth to live a perfect and sinless life, and yet he was destined to die to save the world from their sin. Romans 5:8 says this: "But God demonstrated his own love for us in this. While we were still sinners, Christ died for us." We did nothing to deserve his love, and we did not do anything to deserve Jesus dying in our place, but he did it anyway.

We were never meant to be perfect. We physically cannot be perfect. Therefore, since birth, we were destined to die. But more than that, since birth we were destined to go to Hell. But this was simply unacceptable to God. He is a loving and just God and knew that a sacrifice was needed to save us from our sins. Therefore, He sent his son Jesus to Earth to bear the weight of our sins, and despite being perfect, died for the sake of the world. Heaven is simply one step away. By acknowledging that God is the one true God, and that He sent Jesus to save us from our sins, we can be saved. The road may not always be easy, but a life in the redeeming grace of Jesus Christ is worth it. God keeps no track of wrongs, so all sin gets laid at the cross, never to be looked at again. As soon as you acknowledge Jesus Christ as your Lord and Savior and ask for

forgiveness for your sins, you are no longer broken, ashamed, or defined by anything besides your identity as a son or daughter of God. God is loving, and He desires nothing more than for us to have a personal relationship and spend eternity in Heaven with Him.

In the Potter's Hand

An Exploration of the Sovereignty of God in Ephesians 1: 3-14

By: Kevin Fan

It should not be a surprise to Christians that the central component of a healthy, Biblical hermeneutic is the understanding that the Bible is God's special revelation of Himself to mankind. The Biblical narrative is God's story from start to finish: He is the author, the main subject, the conquering hero, and the point. This confession on our part carries deep and profound implications with it, especially considering the fact that the Bible also records how God has dealt with mankind throughout history. One of them is this: *no matter where we look in the Bible, God's dealings with men always provide us with a window into His character and truth that ought to be met with our worship and delight.*

For example: in Genesis 1, we see God relating to us as His creation; we also see a glimpse of His creative power in that He creates the world *ex nihilo* ("out of nothing"). The famous "Servant Song" of Isaiah 53 shows God relating to us by sacrificing a sinless substitute in our place; in that passage, the ferocity of God's holiness is demonstrated through the crushing of the substitute while the compassionate beat of His heart is shown in His willingness to take our sins and make them His very own. John 3:16, the most famous verse in the Bible, details how God relates to us by sending His own Son to give eternal life to all who believe in Him; the words of the Lord reveal God's love and grace for His people through Christ. To all who abandon their hope in their own righteousness and run to Him in faith, His mercy is great and His grace is free.

The opening verses of Ephesians (Eph. 1: 3-14) have a lot to say about how God deals with those who put their faith in Him for salvation: He blesses us in Christ with "every spiritual blessing in the heavenly places" (v. 3), He adopts us as "sons" (v. 4), He secures for us "redemption through his blood" and "the forgiveness of our trespasses" (v. 7), He reveals to us "the mystery of his will" (v. 9), He gives us an inheritance (v. 11), and He seals us with "the promised Holy Spirit" (v. 13). All of these things, and more, are true of the one who is united with Christ by faith. And while these truths themselves are absolutely worth praising God for, we *cannot* miss the bigger implications of what this passage says about *God*. Because *God* is the main subject here, we must examine the spiritual blessings that every believer has in Christ in light of what they reveal about His nature and character. I believe that a proper exegesis of the opening verses of Ephesians reveals that God is sovereign over salvation, namely in His predestination of specific individuals unto salvation according to the pleasure of His will.

Predestined for Salvation

"Men treat God's sovereignty as a theme for controversy, but in Scripture it is matter for worship."

- J.I. Packer

I'm sure most of us have heard this statement before: "God is in control and He has a wonderful plan for all of us." This is derived from the Biblical doctrine of the sovereignty of God, or the truth that God has and exercises supreme ruling authority over His creation. Psalm 115:3 puts it this way: "Our God is in the heavens; he does all that he pleases."¹

Furthermore, Scripture as a collective testifies that God is *truly* and *completely* sovereign; in other words, *God is absolutely sovereign over all things, without exception, and everything that has ever happened or will happen does so according to His divine decree.* In Isaiah 46: 9-10, God Himself says, "Remember the former things of old; for I am God, and there is no other; I am God, and there is none like me, declaring the end from the beginning and from ancient times things not yet done, saying, 'My counsel shall stand, and I will accomplish all my purpose.'" After God's glorious revelation of His wisdom and sovereign hand in creation to Job (ch. 38-41), Job's meek response is to declare that "I know that you can do all things, and that no purpose of yours can be thwarted" (Job 42:2). Paul, in our text today, writes that God "works all things according to the counsel of his will" (Eph. 1:11). God is not a passive observer who possesses foreknowledge into eternity future, but the active executor of His sovereign will. All of history marches according to what God has decreed from eternity past.

In Ephesians 1: 3-14, the riches of God's grace through Christ highlight a specific part of God's sovereignty: His sovereignty over salvation. The truth that God, in eternity past, chose to save a certain group of individuals (the "elect," or "chosen") according to the pleasure of His sovereign will is woven tightly into the very fabric of this passage in order to demonstrate the sovereign faithfulness of the God who blesses us in Christ. And here's what is interesting: though the concepts of predestination and election² are hotly debated topics in the church today, it is worth noting—no matter what your current soteriological views are (admittedly, Packer and I would share a Calvinistic view)—that the passage we're examining speaks of these things in a manner that the author (Paul, carried along by the Holy Spirit) does not feel the need to apologize for.

Consider verses 4-5, where Paul writes that God "chose us in [Christ] before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless before him," and that "in love he predestined us for adoption to himself as sons through Jesus Christ, according to the purpose of his will." Or consider that Paul continues to say that "in [Christ] we have obtained an inheritance, having been predestined according to the purpose of him who works all things according to the counsel of his will, so that we who were the first to hope in Christ might be to the praise of his glory" (v. 11-12). The doctrine of election is spelled out pretty explicitly in this passage, and Paul intends to explore four major points in relation to it: *who* is predestined, *when* we were predestined, *what* we were predestined to, and *why* God predestined us.

¹ All quotations are from the ESV, unless otherwise indicated.

² The terms "predestination" and "election" are often used interchangeably when referring to God's choosing of a group of individuals for salvation before the beginning of time. If a distinction is to be made, predestination refers to God's general foreordaining of events while election refers to the predestination of the "elect" for salvation.

The questions of *who* and *when* are answered by understanding who Paul's audience is. Paul's letter to the Ephesians is addressed to "the saints who are in Ephesus, and are faithful in Christ Jesus" (Eph. 1:1). This is further reinforced by Paul's usage of "God *our* Father" in verse 2 and "*our* Lord Jesus Christ" in verse 3. In other words, this is addressed to the believing community in Ephesus and, by extension, applies to every follower of Jesus because we who believe today believe in the same Lord, are part of the same Church, and trust in the same gospel as they did. We too have received the blessings of salvation, forgiveness, adoption, and the Holy Spirit in Christ, and those who have received these blessings in Christ (v. 3) are—according to Paul—the same ones who were predestined "before the foundation of the world" (v. 4), or before creation.

As far as *what* exactly we were predestined to, suffice it to say that we who have faith in Christ were predestined to every blessing listed in this passage; I believe this is the case because Paul ties every blessing listed in this passage to *union with Christ*, and he describes our union with Christ as a predestined affair, determined in eternity past by a sovereign God. "Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us in Christ with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly places, *even as he chose us in him before the foundation of the world*, that we should be holy and blameless before him" (Eph. 1: 3-4). The totality of our spiritual blessings are found in Christ, and we were chosen in Christ in eternity past; indeed, Christ is the lamb of God, slain before the foundation of the world (Rev. 13:8). Of course, the greatest blessing that we were predestined to is Christ Himself and the salvation He secures for us, for "in love he predestined us for adoption to himself as sons through Jesus Christ, according to the purpose of his will, to the praise of his glorious grace, with which he has blessed us in the Beloved. In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses, according to the riches of his grace, which he lavished upon us" (Eph. 1: 4-8).

This understanding carries great theological weight because it means God knew exactly what He was doing when He chose us. Everything we have been given—our righteous and holy standing before the throne of God (v. 4), our adoption into His family (v. 5), our redemption by the blood of Christ, the forgiveness that we have received (v. 7), our obtained inheritance (v. 11), and the sealing and indwelling of the Holy Spirit (v. 13)—was ordained from the beginning of time and secured at the cross of Christ. There is, therefore, *no such thing* as luck or good fortune in God's economy, but only divine providence. In our own faith journeys, even the worst things that have happened to us were not unfortunate circumstances that God had to "work around" in order to make His plan happen. On the contrary, events that God had sovereignly ordained specifically in order to draw His elect to Himself and give them true, everlasting life.

Naturally, the big question many ask is *why*? Why would God predestine anyone in the first place, and why would He choose to save someone like me? Although we will never know exactly why, our passage gives us three answers and one huge non-answer. He did so "according to the purpose of His will" (v. 5), He did so "in love" (v. 4), and He did so "to the praise of his glorious grace" (v. 6).

God doing something “according to the purpose of His will” or “according to the counsel of his will” (v. 11) simply means that in His divine wisdom, God did it because *it was His will to do so*. While that may seem like a cop-out answer, it does inform us that there are things in life that only God knows about. Though we may not be given specific reasons for everything that happens in our lives, we who trust God need not wonder all the time because everything that *does* happen occurs according to His wisdom and His sovereignty. As Deuteronomy 29:29 puts it, “The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever.”

The second half of that verse applies to our other two answers because, though there is an element of divine inscrutability to the doctrine of election (meaning that we may never fully know why God specifically chose to save *us*), Scripture *has* revealed several of His motivations in doing so. The first is that He *loves us*. This love of God is different from the general, benevolent love He has toward all of His creation, and we know this because the love that God predestined us in (v. 5) is not extended to all people. Not all people will be saved; Scripture consistently teaches that hell is, in fact, real and will be occupied (e.g. 2 Thessalonians 1:9). The predestination of individuals to salvation is done out of God’s *electing* love for them, and it is that same love by which God the Father unites us to Christ through His shed blood on the cross, pursues us relentlessly until we finally come to Him in faith, and keeps us in His sheepfold until the end. Or, as Romans 8: 29-30 puts it, “For those whom he foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son, in order that he might be the firstborn among many brothers. And those whom he predestined he also called, and those whom he called he also justified, and those whom he justified he also glorified.”

It should be noted that while God predestined His elect to salvation because He loves us, perhaps the greatest motivation behind doing so is *God’s love for God*. By saying that our predestination in Christ was done “according to the purpose of his will, to the praise of his glorious grace” (v. 5-6), that our inheritance obtained through faith in Christ was predestined “to the praise of his glory” (v. 12), and that the sealing of the Holy Spirit as a guarantee of our salvation was done “to the praise of his glory” (v. 14), Paul puts God’s passion for His own glory on full display. Though our pursuit of our own glory would rightfully be labeled self-serving and prideful, God’s pursuit of His glory is not; it overflows in bountiful blessings for His people and culminates in the ultimate display of the glory of God: the crushing of His own Son on the cross. And even *that* was done “according to the definite plan and foreknowledge of God” (Acts 2:23), for the salvation of sinners like you and me. Somehow, some way, God’s decision to choose a group of certain individuals—sinful individuals, I might add—is one that brings Him glory. As a sinner saved by grace, I can only sit and marvel at that truth.

Predestined Without Merit

“I believe the doctrine of election, because I am quite sure that if God had not chosen me I should never have chosen him; and I am sure he chose me before I was born, or else he never

would have chosen me afterwards; and he must have elected me for reasons unknown to me, for I never could find any reason in myself why he should have looked upon me with special love.”
- Charles Spurgeon

Perhaps even more telling is what's *absent* from Paul's explanation of why God predestined His elect to salvation: any reference to the qualities of those individuals whom He chose to save. This passage is centered on God and how *He* blesses *us* in Christ, but nowhere does it even hint at what we had to offer Him. He predestined us because it was *His* will to do so, He predestined us because *He* loved us, and He predestined us because it brought glory to *Him*, but we in and of ourselves never gave Him any reason to do so; this is a doctrine otherwise known as “unconditional election³.”

This is consistent with what the rest of Scripture has to say regarding the doctrine of election. In Deuteronomy 7, Moses addresses the nation of Israel as God's chosen people, and this is what he has to say:

For you are a people holy to the LORD your God. The LORD your God has chosen you to be a people for his treasured possession, out of all the peoples who are on the face of the earth. It was not because you were more in number than any other people that the LORD set his love on you and chose you, for you were the fewest of all peoples, but it is because the LORD loves you and is keeping the oath that he swore to your fathers, that the LORD has brought you out with a mighty hand and redeemed you from the house of slavery, from the hand of Pharaoh king of Egypt. (Deut. 7: 6-8)

Moses is telling the people of Israel why God chose them in particular, and his point is this: God did NOT set His electing love on them because of who they were or anything they did, but because He loved them. In other words, “God chose you and set His love on you... because He loves you.” It is *God* who is the promise-keeper here, it is *God* who is great in power, and it is *God* who gets the glory by defeating Pharaoh (Ex. 9:16).

God's choosing of Israel in the Old Testament is relevant to our discussion on election because His choice to repeatedly save a specific group of individuals out of the surrounding nations is a mere shadow of His choice to save a much larger group of individuals (the true children of Abraham, or “true Israel”) out of the world and from eternal damnation through the person and work of Christ. Here's how Paul draws the connection between the two in the book of Romans:

But it is not as though the word of God has failed. For not all who are descended from Israel belong to Israel, and not all are children of Abraham because they are his offspring, but “Through Isaac shall your offspring be named.” This means that it is not the children

³ “Unconditional election” is one of the “Five Points of Calvinism,” commonly known by the acronym “TULIP.” The other points are Total Depravity, Limited Atonement, Irresistible Grace, and Perseverance of the Saints.

of the flesh who are the children of God, but the children of the promise are counted as offspring. For this is what the promise said: “About this time next year I will return, and Sarah shall have a son.” And not only so, but also when Rebekah had conceived children by one man, our forefather Isaac, though they were not yet born and had done nothing either good or bad—in order that God’s purpose of election might continue, not because of works but because of him who calls—she was told, “The older will serve the younger.” As it is written, “Jacob I loved, but Esau I hated...”

What if God, desiring to show his wrath and to make known his power, has endured with much patience vessels of wrath prepared for destruction, in order to make known the riches of his glory for vessels of mercy, which he has prepared beforehand for glory—even us whom he has called, not from the Jews only but also from the Gentiles? As indeed he says in Hosea, “Those who were not my people I will call ‘my people,’ and her who was not beloved I will call ‘beloved.’” “And in the very place where it was said to them, ‘You are not my people,’ there they will be called ‘sons of the living God’” (Rom. 9: 6-13, 22-26).

By identifying the true children of Abraham as the “children of the promise” (v. 8) rather than national Israel and deliberately looping the Gentiles in as “vessels of mercy” and those “called by God” (v. 23-24), Paul is linking the stories of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob to the electing purpose of God and using them to illustrate the greater reality of God’s election of both Jews and Gentiles to salvation in Jesus Christ. He draws upon the patriarchs in particular in order to make the stunning claim that this is indeed how God, in His sovereignty, has always operated. Furthermore, Paul is again providing the framework for the doctrine of *unconditional* election in his discussion of the story of Jacob and Esau by noting how God’s choice between the two was determined when “they were not yet born and had done nothing either good or bad” (v. 11), thus proving that election was not dependent on who they were or what they did but rather on the sovereign choice of God. He follows this teaching with one of the most jarring verses in the whole Bible: “As it is written, ‘Jacob I loved, but Esau I hated’” (Rom. 9:13).

Dear Christian, it should not amaze us that God hated Esau and rejected him. God is a *holy* God, and He is just; as a lover of righteousness, it is His natural inclination to hate evil and those who do evil (Ps. 5: 4-6). It should also not amaze us that God would eternally condemn sinners to hell, for “all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God” (Rom. 3:23) and “the wages of sin is death” (Rom. 6:23). Rejection and condemnation and eternal hell are mankind’s default position before a holy God because—as uncomfortable as it may be for us to hear—it is what we truly deserve. What *should* amaze us is that God would *love* Jacob (or any other person in the Bible outside of the Lord Jesus, for that matter)! Have we properly considered the laundry list of shortcomings that *saved* individuals have in the Bible? Noah was a drunkard; Abraham *and* Isaac both lied about their wives; Jacob was a deceiver, and his sons sold their own brother into slavery; Moses committed murder; Aaron, the high priest, let Israel build a golden calf

shortly after the Exodus; David committed adultery, murder, and obstruction of justice; Peter denied Christ three times; *Paul* was a blasphemer, a rebel against God, a murderer of Christians, and a persecutor of the church.

What, then, distinguishes these individuals from those who were not saved? What separates Noah and Abraham's families from the world, Isaac from Ishmael, Jacob from Esau, Israel from Egypt, Peter from Judas, and Paul from Nero? What separates you and me from those who will die apart from Christ and under the wrath of God? Paul explains in the following verses: "For [God] says to Moses, 'I will have mercy on whom I have mercy, and I will have compassion on whom I have compassion.' So then it depends not on human will or exertion, but on God, who has mercy" (Rom. 9: 15-16). It is not our works or our righteousness that distinguishes us from the world, but *solely* the grace of God displayed in the cross of Christ and His cleansing blood. Our election *must* be an unconditional election because ultimately, the only satisfactory conditions for our election are not met by us, but by another.

What does this all mean, dear Christian? It means that before He created the world, God in His sovereignty set His saving love on *you* and determined that, by sending the Lord Jesus Christ to live a perfect life, die on a cross while bearing every sin you will ever commit, and rise again in victorious power in order to give *you* eternal life, He would secure an everlasting inheritance and status of sonship for *you*. He would wash *you* clean from your sin, present *you* as holy and blameless in His sight, and lavish the riches of His grace upon *you*, despite all of your sins and your troubles. And it means that He did all of these things for *you* out of the sheer pleasure of His sovereign will; it *delighted* God and *glorified* God to purchase your salvation with the blood of Christ and reconcile you to Himself, despite the fact that you had nothing of value to offer him.

The salvation of God's people through Christ is not some great idea that He just happened to stumble upon; rather, it is the fulfillment of a perfect plan orchestrated by a sovereign God whose purposes cannot be thwarted. Knowing this—that God is indeed sovereign over salvation—is crucial to how we view the blessings that God has given us in Christ because if God's sovereignty over all of this is legitimate, then the blessings that He gives us are also legitimate and can be trusted. If God truly works all things according to the counsel of His will, then we can truly rejoice and proclaim that "Salvation belongs to the LORD!" (Jonah 2:9). And if we who believe in Jesus were truly—before we were ever born—predestined to salvation by God, in love, for His glory, we can find a deeper joy in the Lord when he declares, "I have loved you with an everlasting love" (Jer. 31:3).

Though we who believe in Christ will find—upon honest reflection—our faith in God to be weak and our love for Him feeble, we will also find Him to be a sovereign Potter in firm control over our lives (Jer. 18: 5-6). Indeed, our journey home rests in hands far stronger than ours. From eternity past to our entry into this world, from the day we put our trust in Christ to the day we lay eyes upon Him in glory, He is faithful to keep us in His hand (John 10: 27-30). Rest in that promise, dear Christian. Rest in Christ. Rest in our sovereign Potter's hands.

A Most Urgent Call

*“If your souls were not immortal, and you in danger of losing them,
I would not thus speak unto you; but the love of your souls constrains me to speak:
methinks this would constrain me to speak unto you forever.”*

- George Whitefield

The blessings that believers have in Christ are abundant and everlasting, with the greatest blessing of all being our personal relationship with God. In Christ, we are *His*. And these blessings provide a window for our eyes to see God as a sovereign Savior who is willing and able to save us perfectly to the end. But, dear reader, we must understand that salvation, true life, and these blessings—true blessings—are found in Christ and *Christ alone*. The same Bible that speaks of these blessings also tells us that salvation is found in Christ and “no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved” (Acts 4:12). Perhaps you’ve heard of these famous words from the Lord Jesus Himself: “I am the way, the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me” (John 14:6).

Dear reader, if you currently do not believe in Christ and are not united to Him through faith, you absolutely need to hear this: there is a God in heaven for whom everything we’ve talked about is true, and He created us so that we would *know* Him intimately and personally. This God is holy, righteous, loving, gracious, sovereign, and possessing infinite value; it is against *this God* whom we have sinned. The Bible says that “None is righteous, no, not one” (Rom. 3:10) and that “all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God” (Rom. 3:23). It says that “the wages of sin is death” (Rom. 6:23) and that no amount of “good deeds” that we have done could ever make up for that, for “we have all become like one who is unclean, and all our righteous deeds are like a polluted garment” (Isa. 64:6). If we cling to our own righteousness as our hope for salvation, we have no shot at escaping the wrath of God that will justly fall on us. We are in need of a Savior outside of ourselves, someone who can bear our sins on our behalf and pay for them in full. We are in need of someone who can give us His righteousness and plead our case before the throne of God. There is no other option, no other hope, and no other way for sinners like you and me to get right with God.

My friend, Jesus Christ is that Savior. Though He was God, He willingly left His throne in heaven to become a man and, as truly God and truly man, was born of a virgin. Unlike you and me, He lived a sinless life and, though He was innocent, took the sins of His people to the cross. And as He hung upon that cruel, rugged cross, God the Father poured out His unrestrained wrath upon His only Son instead of us; “But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed” (Isa. 53:5). Jesus Christ willingly endured the wrath of God and paid the full penalty for our sins in death. Three days after His death, He rose again in victorious power to give eternal life to everyone—and I mean *everyone*—who would simply put their faith in Him. After this, He ascended into heaven, where He is alive and reigning today. He did all of this because He loves you! Jesus Christ loves sinners, and He loves to save sinners like you and me.

He lived a perfect life *for sinners*, He died a death *in place of sinners*, He rose again *for sinners*, and He lives today to be the Savior of sinners; indeed, He lives to save all who would run to Him in faith. This is the gospel; this is *good news*! Believe in the Lord Jesus and trust Him to save you from your sins, and you will be reconciled to the God for whom you were made to worship and love. You will have *all* of your sins forgiven and *all* of eternity to rest in the riches of God's grace for you in the Lord Jesus. Run to Christ, and run to Him in faith!

Loved one, do not hesitate to do so. Although we've discussed the sovereignty of God and the doctrine of election today, these things DO NOT absolve you of your responsibility for your own choices before God. If you go to Judgment Day unrepentant and rejecting this gospel, you will find no escape; the sovereignty of God and His predetermined plan will not be an excuse for you. Don't let any doubt of whether you're "actually among the elect" deter you from coming to Christ, for Jesus says in John 6:37, "All that the Father gives me will come to me, and whoever comes to me I will never cast out." If you belong to Him, you *will* come. If you come, He *will not* turn you away, for He has truly paid it all for you; for "*whoever* believes in him shall not perish but have everlasting life."

Everyone who comes to Christ will find Him to be a good, kind, gracious, perfect Savior. So don't wait. *Today* is the day of salvation.

- Kevin

Sola scriptura.

Sola fide.

Sola gratia.

Solus Christus.

Soli Deo gloria.

Life and Campus

Dating IRL

By: Esmee Kuiper and Sommer Motley

A Brief Introduction

Having participated in Christian circles heavily over my college years, we've found that our one-on-one conversations often trend toward one topic: dating. This is natural and makes sense in the context of all the uncertainties of the strange and confusing, transitional time between high school and "real life." In this article, we hope to explore this subject and its relationship to faith and ourselves. Why is dating a great thing? Why is dating tricky, or at worst, unhealthy or even dangerous? What does how we date say about how we perceive God? In an attempt to answer these questions, we will first draw from our personal experiences, then investigate what the Bible says and doesn't say about dating, and finally, explore the practical implications of Christianity on dating. A disclaimer, we are both unmarried (i.e. legally single) college women who are currently in relationships. We don't have all the answers, but the bottom line is this: our main purpose in life is to glorify God in everything we do while growing closer to Him.

Part One: How God Has Worked in Us Through Dating

Esmee's Story

When I was in high school, I was a hopeless romantic. My life, I figured, would be complete if I was able to obtain that coveted position—girlfriend. This goal was the latest in a string of over-achieving, worth-destroying pursuits. Being in a relationship was a box to check, a status symbol that would define my worth, and put a value on my life that other realities could not. For those of us familiar with "justification" (righteousness or "rightness" given to us through faith by Christ alone), what I just wrote is probably a bit appalling. Yet, I am human, and as a human being, I'm enamored with the tangible, the right now, the realness of what my senses can perceive. And in a dating relationship, our senses perceive *a lot* (Sommer Note: The infatuation stage is real).

The problem with worldly justification is that, compared to the grace and love and goodness of God, it's pretty feeble. This was a lesson I learned quickly. Desperate for the fairytale, beautiful love of my romantic dreams, I said yes to the first boy who looked my way. Unfortunately (and fortunately, in so many ways that I'll get to later), this dream was quickly distorted. What started as an intense infatuation stuffed with grand expressions of affection and a pervasive feeling of excitement (a phenomenon I later learned is called "lovebombing") twisted quickly into a rollercoaster of self-doubt that morphed into self-loathing that morphed into self-hatred at the service of my then boyfriend.

I'll spare you the gory details (if you want to know more, send me an email—I'll gladly share my story and how it's changed and nourished my relationship with myself, others, and

God), but needless to say, after two years of painful offs and ons, fights, and big, scary questioning, I finally broke free from a cycle of abuse (if you or someone you know is in an abusive relationship, please see the resources linked at the bottom of this article). I am really happy to say that I'm now in a healthy, fulfilling relationship with someone who respects me, my thoughts and feelings, and my boundaries. What's important here is that in the midst of all the chaos of my younger years, the expanse of exploration in which I was single and healing, and in the peace of my current relationship, I've learned a lot about who I am, what is important to me, and how God is with me as I foster my relationship with myself and others.

All this is very vague, I know, so I'll now be specific. Here is how God was working through it all: first, I was torn down to the lowest of the low. As COVID struck and my unhealthy relationship ended, I felt a complete unworthiness that reached all the way into my marrow. I remember watching *The Notebook* and crying, not because it was sad (though I've done that very thing since—what can I say I'm a softy), but because I was entirely convinced that I would never experience love like Noah and Allie's. Then, I entered a wilderness of myself. For whatever reason (i.e. the Holy Spirit's work within me) I became obsessed with the Old Testament. I poured over these grand stories of heroes and villains and average people making extraordinary mistakes and also, somehow, achieving the incredible, and I saw, more clearly than I ever had before, who God is, and it was, in the weakest of words, incredible.

In learning about God's beauty, I learned more about my own worth. I learned about peace like a river and the joy that it is to be part of God's people and the miracle that is an emotional and intellectual relationship with God. What follows are some thoughts from Sommer and I on the self, relationships, and most importantly, God. This work is not intended to tell you exactly what to do: the Bible doesn't give us dating instructions. Rather, the purpose of this piece, as I see it, is to get you thinking about what is important to you.

Sommer's Story

As girls, we love to talk about boys. Who we like, why we like them, and more specifically if they like us back. Dating is this exciting and fun thing that everyone does. My first boyfriend was someone I dated mostly to understand what the hype was all about. I wanted to learn and understand if dating was something that I could actually do. I chose someone who wouldn't say no, helping me to avoid the pain of rejection. Right after we started dating he found out he was moving away, and to avoid heartbreak I broke up with him over text. Breaking up with someone over text felt awful, and I later apologized to him for the way that I ended things. Growing up Christian, where the message to me was "date to marry," I felt like a failure when I realized I was not going to marry him.

A year later I dated a guy from work who in a lot of ways was a young adult novel romance dream come true. Picnics on the beach, sunset walks in a meadow, bridge jumping in the woods, and a cute movie date were all of the things I had only read about in books. It was the summer before my freshman year at college and when August came around he broke up with me

in my driveway with the excuse that he was “bad with the whole texting thing.” (Esmee note: That’s incredibly lame.)

Both of these relationships were not very deep, I didn’t actually know much about them and most of our time was spent having fun together. The awkward moments like my first kiss and meeting the parents were out of the way, but the memories of feeling unworthy of a text or afraid to say what I was actually feeling left some pretty big scars on my heart. I was terrified of kissing another boy and felt more alone than when I had started dating. After all, neither of them actually knew the real me.

Starting college, I was boy-crazy and was infatuated with every Christian man I met. Both of my previous relationships were with people who said they went to church but didn’t actually believe in living with God. In my first year of college, I flirted a lot, told a guy friend I liked him, and joined dating apps. All of my friends seemed to be dating and I felt like I was missing out. My friends were ditching me for fun dates and when we did hang out seemed to only talk about their boyfriends, something I am still conscious of when talking with friends now that I am in a relationship. I was alone, insecure, and wanting to be known by somebody. I was searching for a life-changing relationship where someone would love the real me.

Dating apps were not the place to solve any of these things. I was on Upward, a Christian dating app, thinking that all of these amazing and Godly men were going to be sliding into my DMs and I’d find “The One”. The promise of easy dating, a plethora of options, and finding my person virtually was too good to pass up. While the DMs did come sliding in, I found Christian men who only cared about future babies, my favorite color, and whether or not I thought getting married young was a good idea. No one actually wanted to get to know me and to be honest, I wasn’t ready to get to know them, either. But since I hate failure, I did end up dating a guy from the app.

He was a youth pastor (he was 21, to clarify) living three hours away. He was kind, an honest Christian man, and loved to talk about the Bible as much as I did. We wrote each other sappy love letters and FaceTimed for hours. He was the first guy in a long time that tried to get to know me. We dated for a very short amount of time, but he changed the way I viewed men. Not all men were selfish, unkind, and arrogant. He helped me believe that maybe there was a man that I could be with and that I deserved better than the crumbs of attention that I was settling for. And so do you.

In these relationships, I realized that I didn’t know a lot about myself or the person I was looking for. I doubted my self-worth and was filled with envy for the people who were blissfully happy in their relationships. I was mad at God for making me a complicated human being with feelings and for allowing me to be hurt by God’s people. Yet, God has redeemed and blessed me by giving me a healthy relationship where I feel supported and known. I am challenged in this relationship to face my fear of vulnerability and to be my authentic self. The fear of being unlovable or unworthy hasn’t gone away fully, but day by day I lean on God to tell me who He created me to be. While I am in a relationship, I find that my perception of dating is always changing to be more like God intended it to be and I am still discovering who I am along the

way. While single, I thought if I had the right guy all of the things I didn't like about myself would fix themselves and my insecurities would cease to exist. Instead of being grateful for the stage of life I was in and being present in my friendships, I was bitter and resentful. I was obsessed with what I didn't have and failed to love myself just as I was. I hope that through sharing my story and analyzing the Bible you can not only better understand God's heart in dating but also God's heart for you.

Part Two: What the Bible Doesn't Say About Dating

When talking about the Bible and dating, people often try to find answers to the following questions: What does Godly dating look like? What is the perfect man or woman for me? How do you know you are ready for marriage? How can I be content being single? I went searching the Bible for answers to these questions and found none. I then went looking for answers in secular and Christian culture. Secular culture doesn't always value marriage or put enough emphasis on commitment. On the other side of the coin, I found Christian culture treating dating like marriage. Christians put a lot of emphasis on dating, purity, and commitment to the extent of dating feeling both unattainable and idealistic. In attempting to find answers in and outside of the Bible, I found that there is meaning and growth in not knowing.

The fact of the matter is that the Bible doesn't talk about dating at all. Historically, dating as we know it today did not exist until the mid-20th century. Before then, women were told to marry men by their fathers. There was no romance or the idea of finding your perfect match. Marriages were contractual and at times granted with ulterior motives, exemplified by David and Micael in the Bible (1 Samuel 18:17-26), and were for the benefit of gaining wealth or status. Love, as we know it, had little to do with marriage. Since dating is not a Biblical concept, dating is going to be messy and difficult to navigate - there is no exact or easy right answer. We make up what is between friendship and marriage and the social rules that we follow. We have to decide for ourselves what those rules are and what we want dating to be.

The Bible also falls short in telling us the qualities of a perfect Christian man or woman. While Proverbs 31, a chapter in the Bible that describes a more Godly woman, is in every Christian man's dating profile, the chapter itself fails to expand upon how a woman may go about expressing those traits in a dating relationship. Examples of great women can be seen in Mary Magdalene, Esther, and Ruth. However, all of these women's stories lack insight and we can't base one perfect woman on them. Besides Jesus, no man in the Bible is flawless either. Some of the men in the Bible portray traits of courage (Moses, Exodus 3:11-12), vulnerability (David, 1 Samuel 30:4), compassion (Boaz, Ruth 2:5-9), and leadership (Joshua, Joshua 23 and 24). You will also find examples of men in the Bible with flawed traits like lust (David, 2 Samuel 11), pride (Peter, Matthew 26), and envy (Essau, Genesis 27). People in the Bible are flawed and that is what makes the Bible relatable to us. If we look to the Bible for examples of great people, we either have to look at all of them, flaws and all, or none of them. There is never going to be a perfect person for you who checks all of your boxes. Only Jesus can do that.

There also isn't a guide to how to be ready for marriage. Whether the question is are you or is your relationship ready for marriage the answer is the same: the Bible doesn't talk about it. I like to think that just as God allows us to choose Him, he allows us to choose marriage. While being ready for marriage is not discussed, marriage is talked about at length. Love is patient, love is kind. It does not boast or envy (1 Corinthians 13:4-8). The kind of love that this verse talks about is not talking about romantic love, but love that God has gifted and called us to embody in every part of our lives - including marriage. Marriage is selfless and it's for life. It's a commitment that transcends fights and disagreements because you are deciding to become one flesh. This means that in marriage you need to believe that your spouse makes you a better person and that you are willing to sacrifice your own selfish desires for the good of your spouse. Additionally, marriage is the closest example that we can get to understanding how Jesus loved the Church. A husband and wife die every day to themselves in order to love each other (Genesis 2:24, Luke 9:23). The level of commitment shown in marriage is not meant for a dating relationship where you are not bound to the same vows. Still, dating allows us to consider what it means to die to yourself for another person and to consider what it would mean to glorify God through our relationship.

While the rest of the world seems to have either found their person or is in the process of trying to find them, how do we stay content with being single? I find that happiness and contentment are often used interchangeably with each other. We are not called by God to be happy, but to be content. The Bible doesn't talk about being content in singleness, but it does tell us how to be content in all circumstances: through the heavenly peace that God provides (Psalm 23:1, Psalm 37:3-5). In fact, Paul tells us that singleness is actually preferred to marriage; it's easier to put your entire focus on God when you aren't compromising for another person.

Since many of these questions aren't answered in the Bible, and secular sources lead us to believe that dating is meaningless with no boundaries necessary, how can we discern what dating as a Christian looks like?

Part Three: What the Bible Does Say About Dating

First, and crucially, the Bible answers the question, "who is God?" As Christians, we believe in the infinite and all-powerful God (Col. 1:17). We believe in a supremely wise and knowing God (Rom. 11:33). We believe in a holy God (Rev. 4:8). Most reassuring, we believe in a good God (Ps. 34:8).

God's goodness and immutability are so crucial when considering dating relationships because it gives us, a) the freedom to take thoughtful risks, knowing that God's plan for his people is unchanging (Mal. 3:6) and b) the comfort of knowing that even when our lives aren't as we had planned or hoped, we are still under the hand of a caring God. That is, we, as God's people, are held closer by God than we could possibly imagine—and that will never change.

The Bible, additionally, tells us who we are. We are made in God's own image (Gen. 1:27). We are God's children (Gal. 3:26). We are intimately made and known by the creator of heaven and earth (Ps. 139). I believe that self-compassion is the natural byproduct of truly

knowing and embodying these truths which comes from understanding and holding what is true about God. In other words, a careful comprehension of the nature of God yields an understanding of who we are which radically changes the way in which we treat ourselves.

If we treat ourselves well, and care for ourselves like the walking, breathing miracles we are, then dating becomes an act of self-love. If we treat ourselves well, and care for ourselves like the walking, breathing miracles we are, then *not* dating becomes an act of self-love.

Part Four: So What? This is 2022

Date Like a Friend

Sommer

If we know who we are, and how we are called to love ourselves and others by God, then naturally our standards in relationships will increase. We won't settle for breadcrumbs of someone's attention or feel content in being someone's second choice. We also won't put someone else down to raise ourselves up. Yet, how do we practically apply what the Bible says and doesn't say right now? For starters, the same level of depth and relationship that you expect in your dating life should start in your friendships. Skills like intentionality, communication, compassion, vulnerability, and patience that can make a dating relationship meaningful can be practiced in your friendships. I believe that when you take your friendships as seriously as your romantic relationships your life is more fulfilling and rich. We were made for community and to live life with people, as in, more people than just a significant other.

One way that I treat my friendships like my relationship is by practicing authentic vulnerability. I share what I actually am feeling when someone I trust asks and I allow my friends to help carry the burdens that life has with me. I am also intentional about the time that I spend with my friends. I carve out time to have authentic check-ins and to care for my friends in the ways that they need. I ask them how I can pray and support them. Just as I try to have healthy communication over conflicts with my boyfriend, I practice healthy confrontation with my friends. When I am upset with them or feel hurt I tell them, and we work through it together. At the base of any romantic relationship should be friendship, and one of the crucial ways to learn how to date well is to learn how to be a better friend.

Undergo Self-Excavation

Esmee

I've always asserted that in order to truly and fully know others, we must be in constant pursuit of ourselves. We must know our innermost parts, our shortcomings, and our strengths while acknowledging that we'll never be whole in our understanding while on this earth. In order to achieve this understanding, this perpetual self-discovery, we have to know God. That's what it comes down to: if we know the God who created us, the Christ who condescended, and the Holy Spirit who lives and breathes and works within and around us, we start to more fully see ourselves as we are. If God did, as Psalm 139 states, "knit [us] together in [our] mothers'

wombs,” then what do that intimacy and intricacy imply about who we are? If it is “by grace [we] have been saved,” how, then, should we treat ourselves?

I’ve heard it said in conservative circles that some Christians are getting “too soft,” that we’re leaning into cultural notions of self-love and living shame-free. However, God visits us in our softness. Jesus weeps. In times of suffering, there is holiness. What would it look like if instead of hiding away our hurting parts, we viewed them as portals for exploration, an opportunity to excavate our own hearts? My lowest points have taught me the most about myself and shown me God in ways I never thought possible.

In the summer of 2020, after leaving my unhealthy relationship, I would go for long walks along the shores of Lake Michigan. My air pods blasting full volume angsty music (the kind that made my mom ask if I was okay), I trekked through the woods, the wind blustery on an entirely gray day. Once I reached the beach, I felt the need to be still. I turned off my music, sat in the cold sand, let the wind berate me, and stared out into the blue horizon. The past two years had been a storm. I had departed the whirlwind of highs and lows, yet I was still plagued by uncertainty and self-doubt. I watched the first lightning strikes of an August thunderstorm come in from across the lake, and I thought about God. I thought about a God who is in charge, who is present. I thought about a God who loved me so much that he carried me from my pit of despair. I was more unsure than I had ever been before—the future that my ex and I had constructed had toppled on its sandy foundation, yet in my loneliness, my profound feeling of alone-ness I felt deeply aware of God, and for the first time in ages, I felt known and loved. I felt a love that was big, all-encompassing. This is the beauty of being single.

Release

Sommer

It is natural to be curious and to want to be prepared for marriage or dating, but obsessing or worrying about your worthiness of something that God has made specifically for you is not what He made you for. Trusting God with your life includes your dating life. You have to trust that no matter what happens, marriage or breakup, God’s plan is always good. God doesn’t make mistakes and He cares about your feelings more than you do. You can trust Him with your feelings because He created them. Dating can come with a lot of fear and insecurity, even in ones that are healthy. For me, my fear comes in not knowing exactly what the future holds for my relationship. I can plan all I want, but ultimately God is in control of all of it. Because I believe that God is always good and that His will is greater than mine, I trust that God’s plan for my life and my relationships will always be purposeful and just. For me, giving my dating life, or lack thereof, to God, meant letting my fear of rejection go, being who I truly am, and not letting my doubts keep me from loving the people in my life to my fullest extent. Ultimately, holding on to fear and insecurity keeps you from loving yourself, loving the people around you, and loving God to your fullest.

Authors' Note: If you have any questions or want to follow-up with either of us to chat we'd love to hear from you.

Resources

[U-M Sexual Assault Prevention and Awareness Center](#)

[Safe House Center Ann Arbor](#)

[National Domestic Violence Hotline](#)

[CDC Intimate Partner Violence Information](#)

How Studying the Bible Enriches the Beauty of My Religion

By: Sommer Motley

One of the most exciting and stressful parts of college is picking your classes each semester. As an engineering student, I am required to take humanities classes to round out my education. Most of my peers take German Fairytales or Greek mythology, but I decided to take two Judaic study classes. I am naturally curious about the Bible and wanted to be more engaged in the historical contexts in which the Bible was written. One of the two classes I took was in the fall of 2021: MIDEAST 280 “The Historical Jesus”. The class aimed to cross reference historical texts with three of the Gospels, Matthew, Mark, and Luke to determine what we can historically know about Jesus if we disregard supernatural or ‘extra’ religious stories. The other class, JUDAIC 382: “Modern Day Questions and the Bible” examines the Old Testament for answers to controversial modern questions about everything from polygamy and homosexuality to wealth redistribution and slavery. As Christians, we are at times cautious to challenge our faith and reluctant to allow the secular world to comment on our beliefs. These classes richly deepened my understanding of the Old Testament and allowed me to intellectually grasp the challenges and beauty of Christianity. Perhaps, after reading this article you too will be encouraged to challenge yourself to engage with your faith in secular education.

As a practicing Christian who believes that the Bible is divinely inspired, I was challenged when my professor told me that we would be disregarding the book of John, one of the four Gospels, as a historical account of Jesus due to its heavy religious themes and notes. John, in his opinion, was not meant to be a historical account and its purpose was to depict the personal and divine characteristics of Jesus—making it unreliable for us to use. In a sense he is right, the book of John is meant to explain that Jesus is God and more explicitly states Jesus’ purpose on Earth, but the book still uncovers a layer of Jesus that the Jewish people believed about him at that time. I challenged myself to temporarily allow the limitations that secular education put on Jesus in order to understand how non-Christians view Jesus. Through this, I was able to understand better how ancient Jewish society shaped the Gospel.

While learning about different Jewish groups and culture to better understand the world in which Jesus lived and comparing the Gospels for historical reliability, I became more in awe of what Jesus offered the Jewish people during His time on Earth. Jesus was despised by the Romans and high Jewish priests, yet He offered hope and freedom from an impossible religious standard set before the Jewish people. While the professor did not refute the fact that Jesus was killed by Pontius Pilate, he did not comment on the resurrection of Jesus. Furthermore, classic Christian beliefs about the virginity of the Virgin Mary, Jesus being born in a manger, and where exactly the body of Jesus ended up were all put into question. Some of these details such as the whereabouts of Jesus’ body after the crucifixion are pivotal to Christianity, while others in my

opinion, like Jesus being born in a manger, are not. This class challenged me to think about the things that are essential to the Gospel and how I hold them to be true within the balance of understanding that the Gospel writers, while divinely inspired, were written by people. People are imperfect and have accounts that don't perfectly align with each other to create a perfect historical account of Jesus. But because they are imperfect, it actually makes their accounts more believable and more likely. In my final essay for this class, I chose to write about how Jesus, who was hated by the Roman Empire and was killed by the very people that He came to save, later on, became the deity of the Roman Catholic Church. One man, the historical Jesus, changed the world in a way that no one else has.

While the class I took last fall opened my eyes to Christianity as an academic study, this fall's seminar, "Modern Day Questions and the Bible", has challenged me to communicate my beliefs in a succinct and intellectual way. Every Tuesday and Thursday I go to class having read a part of the Old Testament and a related modern day article on a controversial topic. During the first few weeks of class, I realized the limitations of my peers', some of whom were Christian, understanding of the Old Testament. The unhealthy relationships that King David had with multiple wives were brought to light, along with a held belief by some people in the room that Boaz, Naomi, and Ruth may have been in a polyamorous relationship. I learned that people across faiths and backgrounds desire to feel respected, supported, and known by their significant other(s). I also learned that people have a hard time deciding when to criticize the Bible and when to accept its truth. When discussing rape, we were all quick to agree that the way the Bible and society at that time viewed women as less than men was wrong. However, in Numbers when there is an account of abortion to determine the fidelity of a woman people were quick to stand by the Bible's supposed stance that the fetus is less important than the woman. Regardless of my own personal stances, these discussions made me realize that people truly do pick and choose what they take from the Bible and rarely contemplate the sometimes seemingly contradictory stances that the Bible might hold.

In another class period, we discussed poverty, charity, and wealth. We all agreed that the Bible encourages people to take care of one another and make sure that everyone has their basic needs met. The Bible also says that land truly belongs to God and therefore we are simply stewards of the Lord's land. Therefore, nothing that we have is truly ours. Charity and generosity are both strong Christian values that I hold and ones that my parents have modeled for me as I grew up in their household. I believe, through my experience, that most Christians hold these values and understand their importance. However, through this discussion, I discovered that non-Christians don't necessarily view Christians as being charitable or generous. The way Christians view themselves is not the image that outsiders always see. Non-Christians were also confused about why the difference between Christian sects not only mattered, but also how they were decided. Just as people questioned the theology and values of Christians, they also missed the mark on the purpose of the Old Testament. As we discussed how sinful and, at times, terrible the society of the Bible was and attempted to apply it to our lives today, most of the time people concluded that it was impossible to perfectly relate the Bible to the modern day. It's sad that the

Old Testament, which paints a story of a world that needs Jesus and is preparing the way for Him to come to Earth, is left as just a moralistic text at best and at worst a text that explains the problems of society at that time. While the problems of society might not change, because Jesus came to Earth and died for our sins, the Old Testament is a story of people waiting for a Savior. In this context, the Bible isn't a hopeless text or in need of any cherry picking. Jesus made us right with God and washed away the mark of all sins.

In the middle of both of these classes stood the tension of who God is. For the class focused on Jesus, God was yet just another character mentioned by Jesus who wasn't directly involved in the Gospel stories. In my Old Testament class, God played a more centralized role in the texts we studied. In a world where Jesus doesn't exist, a world I argue all non-Christians live in, God is judgmental, angry, misunderstands humans, and follows no human reasoning. God delivers justice in order to make the Jewish people right with Him for their sins through genocide, suffering, and ridicule. He also gives out mercy in a way that makes no sense to the human mind. As a Christian, I see God's acts of justice and mercy as the crux of His divine sovereignty over good and evil. The Old Testament from my view isn't about a senseless God who doesn't care or who lashes out - He is trying to make a world plagued with evil choose a better and more righteous path. Without Jesus, the price of our sins and the treason we held against God was too high for us to fathom and so his actions of righteous justice are what we truly deserve. Still, God's perfect love for us would never abandon us. He is partial to mercy and love above all else for those who will turn to Him. This is one way that God revealed a part of Himself to me and the story of His being.

These classes have sparked many fruitful conversations about faith with believers and non-believers that will forever shape me. I understand now how beautiful the Bible is not just because of the emotional response it provokes and the spiritual guidance it provides, but also because of the great historical story it tells. When I have told pastors in my life or other Christian leaders, they almost always are skeptical of my experiences. They are upset that the university would teach the Bible disregarding any religious value it might have and that they lack Christian professors. They also worry that it will weaken my beliefs and cause me to question my faith. However, it is because of the questions I have been asked to examine that I know more about my faith. I know where the Bible may fall short without full context and understanding of its intent. I am not afraid to sit in the discomfort and tension of not knowing my belief or answer when first asked. I also now know how to listen to others who don't believe what I do and have a constructive conversation about the morals of the Bible. While challenging my faith, these classes were not designed to make me unbelieve. Their intention to make me think about the Bible differently and to find meaning in it outside of religion made me fall more in love with God as the author of the Bible and Jesus as both the savior of the world and a man that drastically changed ancient Jewish society. I challenge you to take a leap towards faith and trust the God that you know is the same God that secular scholars study. Allow yourself to ask questions about the Bible and deepen your understanding of your faith outside of Christian circles.

Making Amends

By: Daniel Koning

“If your brother or sister sins against you, go and point out their fault, just between the two of you. If they listen to you, you have won them over. But if they will not listen, take one or two others along, so that ‘every matter may be established by the testimony of two or three witnesses. If they still refuse to listen, tell it to the church; and if they refuse to listen even to the church, treat them as you would a pagan or a tax collector.”

Matthew 18:15-17

When someone sins against you or hurts you, it is much easier to talk to others about it than to talk to that person. However, Scripture tells us to do just that: have a conversation with that very person. If we don’t follow this and talk, gossip, about that person, then we have wronged them in turn. “Without wood, fire goes out, without gossips, conflict dies down (Proverbs 26:20).” Avoiding a conversation with the correct person will exacerbate the issue. Of course, in some circumstances, it isn’t safe to talk to a person that hurt you and this passage, Matthew 18, should not be read in ignorance of that.

This passage is not to be treated as a checklist to go through to justify cutting a person out of our lives. Rather, it is a Biblical set of steps to take when we want to fix our relationship with a person after they have hurt us. If all attempts to reach and connect with the person fail, Matthew 18:17 says “treat them as you would a pagan or tax collector.” Now, how are the Jews, Matthew’s audience, to treat pagans and tax collectors? Pagans and tax collectors were outsiders to the Jews, they were not part of their community. However, they weren’t to be hated or despised – although that is often how they were treated by the Jewish community. Jesus, who is speaking here in the book of Matthew, interacted with those groups and even dined with them in spite of the social norms.

When we are angry with a person, resolving the conflict is urgent. Jesus said, “if you bring your gift to the altar and there remember your brother or sister has something against you leave your gift at the altar and go. First, make things right with your brother or sister and then come back and offer your gift (Matthew 5:23-24).” When we remember the ways in which we have wronged people, resolving that becomes our first priority. As Jesus said, it even comes before gifts to the Lord, a display of reverence to God. This “gift” brought to the altar was sometimes grain or incense, but also sometimes an animal (see Numbers 15). It would be better for a person to leave behind a gift to God, an animal that could possibly run away than to wait one moment before making amends with a person. That is how highly God values our relationships with one another.

Now, then a person does come to one of us because they have wronged us, how are we to respond? The scripture is very clear on this matter as well. Ephesians 4:31-32 says, “put aside all

bitterness, losing your temper, anger, shouting, and slander, along with every other evil. Be kind, compassionate, and forgiving to each other, in the same way God forgave you in Christ.” Now, this is a tall order. When we want to shout at someone, we should be kind; when it would be easy to slander them, we should be compassionate. “In the same way God forgave you in Christ.” That is how we should forgive. Christ died to forgive us. To continue this thought, “if you forgive others their sins, your Heavenly Father will also forgive you (Matthew 6:14).” Yes, we are forgiven and we can forgive because God forgave us first. “But if you don’t forgive others, neither will your Father forgive your sins (Matthew 6:15).” This is quite literally damning. I believe that we are saved by faith in Christ alone, but part of having real faith is living and acting out that faith. Part of having faith and trusting in God is loving and forgiving God’s people, even when you don’t want to. This becomes complicated in cases of assault or rape. It would take someone a measure of audacity to tell this to a person with that experience. The truth is that no one can really say that on their own; that authority comes from God and His word, scripture. No one can force anyone to forgive and no one should try forcing that. However, forgiveness should be practiced.

All of these passages and this advice sound wonderful, and they are, but living up to them is not comfortable. When broken down, it doesn’t always make sense why asking for forgiveness or telling someone that they hurt you is so uncomfortable. It could be that there is shame in admitting to a fault. Or that we don’t want to make a person feel bad for what they have done because it really wasn’t *that* bad. Maybe it’s that Satan is putting up barriers in our relationships to break us each down. While we might feel any of these ways, I know what *isn’t* a good reason: that forgiving each other doesn’t make a difference and doesn’t make anything better. Now I want to clarify, apologies and forgiveness do not fix what happened, it was still bad and hurtful and there might be trust to be lost. Despite this, making amends with a person makes a difference. Taking the time and effort to apologize shows respect and care to a person. If there is a person in your life that you respect or care for, it is critical that you are able to both apologize and forgive each other.

One very simple example from my life was when one day at church I made a joke about a friend of mine spending all of her time with her boyfriend. It got a few laughs, but I knew the comment was disrespectful and out of line. Although I felt bad about it, I didn’t really know how to apologize and, for whatever reason, didn’t really consider apologizing for it. However, later that day, that friend came up to me and told me that she was hurt by what I said. She could have just as easily told someone else about how I had been mean, but she didn’t, and for that I am thankful. Once she told me how she felt, I then had a clear path to apologizing for what I had done and did so. That simple thing lifted a weight off my chest, and I know it did a similar thing for her. I knew what I did was wrong and should have taken action myself, but didn’t. However, she then took action and the situation was able to be resolved. Since then, because we were able to have that conversation, I would say that we have become better friends. It was so simple and took only about five minutes, maybe not even, but it made a tangible difference. It is so easy to skip out on all the little problems we might have with one another, but we shouldn’t just grit and

bear it when someone hurts us or vice versa. Now, as already stated in this essay, we should not be obnoxious about it, but if we aren't able to apologize and forgive each other for the small things, we will never be able to do it when it comes to something that can't simply be overlooked.

Character Matters

By: Ethan Wilmot

Character is the representation of someone's beliefs, morals, behaviors, and values. This representation takes the form of actions that someone demonstrates in their daily lives. The Bible describes character as love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. Representation of these values in our daily lives is an essential part of being a Christian. In 1 John 2:6, John writes, "Whoever claims to live in him must live as Jesus did." If we claim to be Christians and hope to live in a world that more closely resembles the life and teachings of Jesus, these values should be at the heart of all that we do and believe.

Many Christian leaders throughout history have emphasized the need for character to be demonstrated in our leaders. From the earliest foundations of our country, leading by example has been a core facet of what Christian leaders should be. Pilgrim and leader of the Plymouth Colony in Massachusetts, John Winthrop, famously sought to create a "city upon a hill," citing the excerpt from the Sermon on the Mount. Matthew 5:14 says, "You are the light of the world. A city on a hill cannot be hidden." Being a Christian means to demonstratively act differently than those who are not based on an authentic and genuine belief in the Gospel. If there is nothing in our actions that separates us from those who do not believe, then our faith is hypocritical and ingenuine. Through these visible examples, the importance of Godly character is seen, and in no place is more important than leaders who represent us in elected office.

If character is important for Christians to exemplify in all that they do, we should expect more out of those who represent us. Our vote is not just selecting someone who will do what we would like them to do, but to be someone who we want them to be. For our elected officials, character should be one of the factors that Christians consider most when choosing a candidate. But is it? If you've looked at the state of American politics in the last few years, you would probably guess not. American politics is plagued by incalculable failures of character by elected officials from both parties. Every day, there are new stories of someone who the public had entrusted with their votes demonstrating a lack of integrity, a moral failure, or a refusal to stand against the crowd and stand for what is right. In many cases, these elected officials are Christians or at least claim to be.

Good character is an important qualifier for those seeking elected office. For those who claim to be and hope to receive the votes of Christ-followers, character is even more important. It represents the internal desire that those candidates have to live like Christ. It shows a willingness to be the bigger person and to act with integrity. It shows an understanding of what really matters in this world. These values should mean more to candidates than winning some political fight or policy battle. These values should mean more to a voter than a candidate's opinion on tax law, foreign policy, or even abortion.

Despite these truths, elected officials continue to disappoint us, and candidates continue to be elected in spite of glaring differences in what they claim to believe, and how they actually

act. One would think that the Christian church would be leading the charge in encouraging candidates to display these traits and opposing those who do not. But this is not the case. In recent years, especially since the 2016 election cycle, I have seen morally bankrupt candidates and officials defended by Christians on three different grounds that in no way justify their election.

Too often, candidates with clear moral issues are excused and defended based on the promise of political expediency. Defenders argue that these character faults are minuscule in comparison to the potential good that the candidate's policies could accomplish. They argue that these character flaws should be ignored in hopes of electing someone who will enact their preferred policies. This is wrong. Policy should never outweigh the character of a candidate. Good character is usually an indicator of good policy, not the other way around. If we truly trust in God's plan, we should put our trust in those who live like Christ, and trust that God's divine power will follow them.

Many defenders of candidates with poor character justify their votes by pointing to the other side. They argue that "the other side" is winning and that their evil is spreading. They argue that the threat of their opponents is so great, that politics must be fought like a war, with brutality and sacrifices of moral character. This whataboutism only leads to the destruction of what they are fighting for in the first place. When politics are treated like a war, where any action by your side is justified because of the inherent evilness of the other, you lose sight of what really matters. The sins of "the other side" cannot be used to justify our faults on our own. In 1 Peter 3:9, Paul wrote, "Do not repay evil with evil or insult with insult. On the contrary, repay evil with blessing, because to this you were called so that you may inherit a blessing." Where good character exists, good policy will follow, not the other way around. Let us not stoop to the ways of the world in a fight that we cannot win on our own.

The most disappointing way in which Christians justify leaders with bad character is through blatant denial and conspiracy. This is the most difficult to address because those engaging in this defense are not acting in good faith, or with good reason. When faced with accusations against their preferred candidate, many instinctually deny the allegations or proclaim some sort of conspiracy working against them. They rally to their selected candidate with a sense of purpose and a duty to defend. Any criticism of "their side" is invalid because "their side" is perfect and has never been in the wrong, especially compared to the other side. In reality, the opposite should be true. Christians should be more critical of candidates we support than their opposition. Because we hold ourselves to a higher power who has taught us how to live and how to treat others, we should be diligent in our selection of who we choose to represent us. We should not treat accusations with denial or conspiracy, but instead a dedication to the values in which we believe.

These defenses of poor moral character in our leadership are intolerable. Character should be considered above all else in elections. With our faith in God and his perfect plan for our world, we should adhere to the Godly principles that he has set before us, and not rely on our own worldly understanding of how that plan comes to be.

Christian voters can do better. Christian voters need to do better. Clear flaws in character should be an instant disqualification for office. Candidates' refusal to address these weaknesses, repent, apologize, and take responsibility should tell us everything we need to know about them. No policy is worth the degradation of our values. No policy is worth settling for a candidate that does not represent Christ in a positive manner. In order to accomplish this, there must be greater scrutiny of candidates, especially within party primaries. Character should be prioritized as the first thing people look at when considering a candidate. We should have discernment in our decisions moving forward, and recognize our past mistakes. Our priority should not be to identify with a person or party, but to place our identities and our priorities in Christ. He, who makes all things, knows all things, and loves all things, deserves our faith shown through our actions.

Testimonies

Discernment

By: Ivan Kalla

Christianity as a whole is an ever-growing religion with countless followers added daily. It's no surprise that there are various controversies within the church, including different interpretations of the text and a growing divide between belief systems. At the end of the day, the branch of Christianity you choose is completely personal, and although it can be informed by priests, apologetics, family, and other sources, it is a decision between you and God. My journey through discernment will be discussed, but this is merely to share my journey and not to persuade. This is more of a discussion of my own personal revelations in life, but I feel like it is important for each person to seek discernment. Everyone has their own vocation that can only be discovered through prayer and meditation between yourself and God, so although I am not here to persuade, I encourage everyone to seek discernment regardless. This article will discuss my experiences that led me to make big decisions and help me piece together my vocation, so I hope my story encourages everyone to inquire more about their own faith and self-reflect on their own lives.

To start, discernment itself is a way to make a big decision and discover your own calling, whether it be in your faith or other important aspects of life. It is a state of prayer and meditation where you make a big decision concerning yourself. I grew up a Chaldean Catholic Christian and loved every single bit of it. As I grew up, I partook in all of the ceremonies that Catholics would go through, such as Baptism, confirmation, eucharistic celebration, and various others. My family was devout, so I would go to Sunday school, celebrate masses every Sunday and celebrate Catholic holidays with my family. I never questioned it. I was too young and my commitment to Catholicism was of no question at that time. It's the same for most kids, they would never question their belief system or they would have some sort of existential crisis. I lived in blissful ignorance of my faith, blindly following rules and regulations with no understanding of how they came to be or the history behind them. My entire family was also involved in the church and no one went against the wave, so it would be strange of me to question them. As I grew up, I felt disconnected in my relationship with God and chose to prioritize other materialistic things, such as video games, sports, and friendships. My family eventually let me take control of my religion and stopped enforcing Sunday schools and Bible studies, so I chose to stop going. I drifted away from the church since there was no obligation anymore with my family. I still identified as a Catholic, but I never actively pursued my duties as one. As I approached my freshman-sophomore year, the disconnect was so strong that I considered agnosticism, because the church traditions never made any sense to me. However, I never pursued any answers and continued in my ignorance. I ignored it as an escape. I never wanted to consider God as something that is tangible and close to me. God never helped with the problems that I experienced, I had to work for it myself with no help. I saw my Catholic duties as customary as going to school, and never tried to appreciate and be thankful for the foundation

and morals that I gained as a Catholic. At that time, my brother pushed me to attend Bible studies, but I found that the groups went for other reasons than to study Biblical topics.

It was at this time that I was forced to go on a Catholic retreat and felt a stronger relationship with God than I ever had before. It was heavily focused on meditation, and the worship events and the community it fostered gave me a stronger foundation for my faith than I had before. Some turning points that I had throughout the trip included being slain in the spirit twice throughout the trip. Essentially, this meant giving up full control of your body and letting the holy spirit enter your body. As the priests would call down for the holy spirit, people would begin passing out and crying in sporadic bursts. The first time I got slain, my mind went blank and I just started staring at a wall for what seemed to be 3 minutes but turned out to be 45 minutes. I was extremely confused, but a volunteer read me a quote from the Bible that confusion meant peace. The second time I got slain, I went unconscious for around 10 minutes and woke up in a joyful mood. I could not stop laughing for 12 hours straight, which surprised me but realized that the spirit put me in joy. This confusion and joyfulness was a pivotal point that never allowed me to question the existence of God again. I became interested in Catholic topics, such as the Eucharist, deuterocanonical Biblical books, and confession. Community groups were made and I took every opportunity I could to join Christian youth groups and Bible studies. I read Christian novels and picked up the Bible more frequently. The discernment from following out of my faith and into my strong foundation as a Christian began with this retreat.

In my venture to learn more about my faith, I took an opportunity to go to a Bible study that was not Catholic. I was invited by my friend to a different church which was Pentecostal. I entered the building, and the community seemed more energetic and lively than a usual Catholic group. Keep in mind, I was aware that different branches of Christianity existed, but I had no idea where the fine line was between Catholicism and other branches of the church. I sat down throughout the Bible study and the speaker was a very enthusiastic male which was odd to me. I asked various questions to them after the lecture, but the short story is that Pentecostal (and various other non-catholic) branches did not follow the customs that I was used to seeing in Catholic churches. They would follow “Sola Scriptura”, or the conviction that Christian ideologies are set by scripture alone, and not the early Catholic church. Certain prayers and customs seemed alien to them, but they made logical sense to me. I would go to their Bible studies weekly and ask them questions, then go back to my Catholic friends to see if they could explain our Catholic roots.

Another turning point in my religious journey was my weekend trip with a Pentecostal church. I was relatively close with them and I felt comfortable taking the trip, so I decided to go since I was still riding this spiritual high throughout the summer. The community was so friendly and welcoming that the emphasis on the love of God through community resonated with me. There were many times to openly worship and meditate throughout the trip. The theme of the retreat was to discover your calling by looking at your passions and skills, then meditate on God’s wisdom. My ability to inquire and question how everything came to be made me realize that I wanted to pursue Christian apologetics. I realized that I had to read the Bible more, talk to

more priests and pastors, and do a lot more research to achieve this dream. I pondered on this idea and realized that I might want to do Catholic apologetics. I had to look at both perspectives as a Christian and a Catholic. On one hand, as a Christian, I felt a more personal connection with God throughout my time with the Pentecostal church. Although it was not based on the Vatican church, their idea of following the Bible solely was very unconstricted. However, I felt that my personal connection with God had a very emotional foundation, which could be cast away easily. I looked to the Catholic church and the Catechism of the Catholic Church (the essential Catholic writings by a pope) for answers as to why Catholics do the things they do. There were many findings and discoveries, from the Apostolic succession and the image of Mary to the Council of Trent and Catholic prayers. My research into these made me realize that there was consideration for each part of Catholic traditions that I never sought to look into. I used to think it was weird since these traditions were not directly in the Bible, but the idea that certain themes can be extracted from the text was interesting. For example, the quote giving Apostles the power to confess sins as opposed to openly confessing their sins straight to God comes from John 20, where God is talking to his apostles after his death and he says, "Receive the Holy Spirit. If you forgive anyone's sins, their sins are forgiven" (John 20: 22-23). This is a prime example showing that apostles, who went on to anoint further apostles who would also have this power, only have the authority on Earth to forgive sins. There are various other cases here that have been argued for decades, but this is a prime example that I discovered. The idea that the Catholic Church has been around for centuries without changing is a testament to its strong foundation as the truth of the Lord.

I loved being constantly challenged, so I kept joining groups as I transferred to college and joined CRU (a non-denominational Christian organization) which had Bible studies weekly. We would look at the various ways a Biblical text could be interpreted, although Catholics usually have only one way to read a text. We would look into the New Testament and deeply delve into the text for ways that the passage could help us live better as Christians. One debate I had with the group was our discussion about faith and works. It stems from the argument in James that faith without works is dead. I had opposing ideas that works combined with faith lead to salvation, and that works are a product of your faith, so they can co-exist and be the product of the other. However, others would tell me that faith, and faith alone, is all that is needed for salvation. Looking back, both ideas were correct since the "faith alone" ideology could just mean that works come as a byproduct of your faith. I continuously went to CRU for these eye-opening arguments that would oppose my ideas. I would definitely lose arguments occasionally, but it would allow me to do more research on the topic, read about the perspectives of the topic from a non-denominational and a catholic standpoint, and let the topic marinate in my mind so I could piece together a new argument. As someone who is interested in apologetics, I have to understand the answers to these questions from both perspectives so I could create my own thesis on certain topics. After this, I could challenge my other CRU members and have their own faith be challenged in return. A proverbial way of thinking of these debates would be, "As iron sharpens iron, so one person sharpens another" (Proverbs 27:17).

Overall, I concluded that I will continue to be a Catholic Christian, but am undecided on whether I want to go into Christian or specifically Catholic apologetics. Discernment was my journey throughout all these different places, from a time when I felt disconnected from my faith completely to a time when I would actively look for challenges to the Catholic church to debate. This discernment is a never ending process though, and although my resolution is strong with my faith, I am always willing to be challenged. I encourage everyone to accept challenges, because it stirs up debate and allows growth in their comprehension of their faith. Throughout the entire journey, I would constantly self-reflect upon my own religion and inquire more about my own faith. I hope that everyone reading would seek discernment even from a non-religious perspective, because each person has their own vocation that God has planned for them, as stated in Jeremiah, “‘For I know the plans I have for you,’ declares the Lord, ‘plans to prosper you and not to harm you, plans to give you hope and a future’” (Jeremiah 29:11). With discernment, there is self-discovery to a calling that everyone should seek.

Creative Writing

The One Who Sees Me

By: Sommer Motley

Genesis 16:13 “You are the God who sees me and...I have now seen the One who sees me.”

*Sitting at the stop light,
Surrounded
By tall buildings,
Hustling walkers wandering in
The haze of city air and clumps of bustling cars.*

I feel

*Like another number.
A nameless face,
working,
to escape the race that never ends.*

*And no one knows
Who I am.*

*But I look up
To seamless clouds in the sky
birds chirping in swaying trees
smiles on nameless faces.
Creation
Hangs in the air.*

*Maybe it's luck or chance
That brings a smile unto my face
When the unexpected will is done.*

*But it's more personal.
A gift
Carefully wrapped
For me.*

Do I even truly know me?

Do I understand

My past

My Present

My Future

Or

Am I in the dark

Just like

Everyone

Else.

How do the tangled parts of me

intertwine to make sense of all the broken pieces,

shiny fragments.

For I am just another soul

Searching

For what may or will or can.

Still,

My life is a story connecting in ways

That make me feel

Known and

Loved.

The messy tangles of me bring about art

That inspires

And brings me closer

To something

breathtakingly beautiful.

There is One that

Sees my heart and soul,

Sings my song before I open my mouth

And listens with an open heart.

There is One that

Plants flowers in graves,

Lights a fire in my hopeful eyes

And comforts my bleeding soul.

*There is One that
Will never leave
Or desert me in my time of need.*

*There is One that
Watches me as He watch the stars twinkle in the sky
And tends to the broken glass and shattered pieces of this world.*

*There is One that
Knows my name
And calls me His*

*And because The One
Has chosen me
As His child
And the keeper of His art.
I now can know
The One
Who sees
Me.*

In a world where we are searching for the purpose of our life, and trying to make sense of all of the pieces that make us who we are, things can seem so fragmented. When contemplating choices about life after graduation, I found myself drawn to the small things around me that brought me joy. These small, inconsequential things, seemed almost random, and yet still meant for me. One way that I experience God is through the small things in life that bring me little spurts of happiness. No one else notices them or sees them but me. In this small way, I connect with God in a personal and deep way. This verse in Genesis describes that God sees me - the Creator knows my soul intimately. That is a big concept to grasp, and still it brings me comfort to know that God already knows all of the pieces of me. And beyond that, we can know God and His heart and character. He chooses us to be stewards of the Earth, and allows us to know Him just as deeply as He knows us. Just as God sees us we can see Him as well.

Healing in His Wings

By: Kevin Fan

Malachi 4:2

My soul, are you struggling, tired and weak?
Are your burdens hard to bear?
Are the things of earth now rid of joy,
And your hope no longer there?
Even now, the gospel is for you, bringing hope beyond your dreams;
For there is a Son of Man who rose with healing in His wings.

My heart, you were brimming bright with joy,
Now you're troubled by this life;
Where sin and shame seem to ever reign,
And you never cease to strive.
Fear not, Jesus truly bore your sins, He's the Son of suffering;
And He is the Son of Man who rose with healing in His wings.

My bones, are you dragging wearily?
Are you tired from all your toil?
Come under your Savior's easy yoke,
For His treasures never spoil.
He will finish His good work in you, despite what tomorrow brings;
For the Son of Man has died and rose with healing in His wings.

One day, my breath will fade away
And my body see the grave;
'Till then, I am a sojourner
Who trusts my God to save.
His life, His death, His righteousness, my hope will rest on these;
For Jesus rose and lives today with healing in His wings.

Oh, what provision He has made
For His impoverished saints!
There is a Son of Man who rose
With healing in His wings.

In the Hands of My Great Savior

By: Kevin Fan

John 20: 27-28

In the hands of my great Savior lie a pow'r unknown to man:
Strength to order starry heavens and the earth by His command.
What a wondrous, good creation, God's own glory veiled within;
Fallen due to man's rebellion, sharing in the curse of sin.

In the hands of my great Savior lie His good redemptive plan:
Bear the sins of all His people on Himself, the Son of Man.
What a worthy, pure Redeemer come to bruise the serpent's head;
Like a lamb led to the slaughter, walking in my place to death.

In the hands of my great Savior drove the nails on Calvary,
Where His body hung there broken on that cruel and cursed tree.
What a grand propitiation facing wrath to set me free,
Though He had not known transgression, God crushed Him to pardon me.

In the hands of my great Savior hold eternal life to save,
For He rose again on Sunday and He's overcome the grave!
What a brave, heroic Victor! Christ the Lord, our Great High Priest;
Lamb of God, my near Redeemer, Mighty Warrior, Prince of Peace.

In the hands of my great Savior hold the weakness of my own
When He beckons me to worship as I bow before His throne.
What a joy so everlasting, that one day I'll see His face;
In a land where all are singing of the riches of His grace.

O Gracious Lord

By: Kevin Fan

John 10: 27-28

O Gracious Lord and Shepherd mine, do not from me depart;
My soul can't find its rest without Your gentle, lowly heart.
For in Your cross I place my hope and find security;
It is by grace and faith alone I live eternally.

O Gracious Lord, my Providence, a wondrous truth I see;
That You have set Your countenance and saving love on me.
Though Satan has his cunning plans, this grace brings me relief;
My faith is weak and feeble still, but Lord, I do believe.

O Gracious Lord, my Sabbath rest, I need no other plea,
For "It is finished," it is done; I know Your grace is free.
The mount of crucifixion calls; the cross now beckons me
To run the race with confidence and love as You loved me.

My Gracious Lord, my Blessed Hope, I know You won't depart,
For I have tasted and have seen the beauty of Your heart.
You've reconciled me for good, salvation's guaranteed;
And though this world will pass away, one day Your face I'll see.